dear aged scotch

Scotch 'n' Soda Theatre Alumni Newsletter
Spring 2020



AN EVENING WITH THE SMITHS

Tick tock goes the clock and we move through the absurd, the occult and the political in Spring 2020!

. The Bald Soprano . Tistroupe . Detour . Broadway's My Beats . Cloudbanks . S'n'Sings



The Bald Soprano

Time for a good English laugh!

Director Zoe Marshall says, "Imagine, if you will, a play so wacky, it would probably make more sense in its original language. We had a blast working together to create Ianesco's world, from our confrontational choreography to our chalkboard walls. Our actors were quick on their toes, and often left the audience thinking: 'huh?' "



No Parking Players: Detour Occult

It's time to get spooky

Light your candles and grab your hooded cloaks, because this year's Detour improv festival took a turn for the Occult! In its third incarnation, Detour saw 18 incredible improvised performances from college troupes, local Pittsburgh acts, and beyond! Notable features include the aptly-named Friday night closer Death Show, where the performers act through the 5 stages of grief after the "death" of an audience member. Saturday night's closing act featured George and Martha, an old couple that had been married - seemingly - since the beginning of time. The Studio Theatre took the form of their living room, and the audience was soon witness to their squabbling. Detour also hosted a number of NPP alumni, whom we are always so excited to see performing again! The Detour festival was made possible in part to your donations this year, and we cannot thank you enough!

Apart from Detour, the No Parking Players have also been working hard on their improv comedy workshops, even showcasing their "Workshoppers" at the Spring festival. Artistic Director Natasha Shukla (CIT, '21) has been working to keep NPP growing and changing this year, alongside our favorite group of improvisers. We are looking forward to seeing them getting into all sorts of antics once again - hopefully very soon!





Broadway's My Beat

We're on the radio now!

Scotch'n'Soda was very sad that we wouldn't be able to put on our annual Carnival musical, but this did not stop us from putting on a show. We were thrilled when WRCT reached out to the organization about the idea of putting on a radio show. Broadway's My Beat is a radio show series that follows detective Danny Clover as he solves crimes on the streets on Broadway. Clover, voiced by Ayda Ozdoganlar, meets many unusual, suspicious characters as he tries to uncover who murdered this episode's victims.

The show presented a new, exciting challenge for S'n'S, an organization that does not typically explore voice acting. The cast of nine included many veterans and a couple new faces to S'n'S including Anjali Thontakudi, who voiced the Manager, and Govind Menon, who voided the Announcer and Officer Tartaglia. The project ran on a short timeline in order to be aired by Carnival weekend, giving the team just about a week to cast, rehearse, record, and edit the show. The editing was thanks to the skill of Grant Martin whom also voiced Marly on the episode. Although it wasn't the show we had originally planned, S'n'S is very thankful to have had the opportunity have found a way to explore a new style of theatre and continue to do what we love: make shows with and for our friends.



Cloudbanks

Into the future once more

"Over fifty years into the future, memory is digital - at a cost. When memory is eternal but space is limited, what do we hold dear? What happens when grief is an emotional, physical, and digital burden? What does it cost to store, lose, forget, move on? How do we make room for the future, and what do we pass down to our children?"

In the words of the cast and production team, this play is a work of active transformation; born out of curiosity for our imagined futures and given new meaning in a world where connection is coded by isolation. Cloudbanks, an original play by Joshua Kery, embraces the unknowns of art in the wake of social distancing and explores what happens to our relationships when filtered through a screen.

S'n'Sings

It's time to sing!

Inspired by Eric Whitacre's Virtual Choirs, S'n'Sings is a virtual collaborative musical performance! Org members individually recorded themselves singing vocal parts, which were then edited together to create a cohesive performance. S'n'Sings was a way for us to highlight the immense talent of individuals in the org, as well as celebrate what we can create when we come together – even in the time of a pandemic. S'n'Sings consists of performances of "Side by Side by Side" from the musical Company, music directed by Ruiran Xun; "For the Longest Time" by Billy Joel and "Baba Yetu" by Christopher Tin, both music directed by Aria Paradkar. All of the videos and audio were edited by Jacqui Fashimpaur, Nicole Packard and Ruiran Xun.

Though we may physically be all across the country, S'n'Sings has allowed us to be and perform together. It's been difficult functioning as a social org during this pandemic, particularly when creating art and performance, but this Board Project has shown us that it's possible to create something really meaningful. S'n'S is an org of incredibly skilled artists, and we put together something beautiful with each other and for each other!



Tisbert 2020

Don't forget to vote!

Tisbert launched what would have been a semester packed with comedy in February with Tisbert 2020.The inaugural show featured the performance troupe, Tistroupe, clad in their most patriotic attire, performing a variety of sketches written by the members of Tisbert as a whole. The show was markedly different in form than that of previous shows held in the Studio Theatre; the group aimed for more of a pared-down approach, with minimal lighting and sound and an increased focus on writing and performance. Among the sketches performed included a fourth-wall breaking performance of the Star-Spangled Banner, a woman deep in debt due to her Sonic the Hedgehog obsession, and some surprise cameos from "Richard Attenborough." We saw some familiar faces, like current Artistic Director Nathan Blinn (DC, '21) and Head Writer Katie Tender (CFA, '20), and some newly-minted members too, like Sam Deadrick (CIT, '21) Madeline Elston (DC, '22) and Josh Cagan (DC, '21). The sketches had their familiar Tisbert flair, with unpredictable characters and impossible scenarios.

Spring 2020 would have seen the first instance of "refreshed Tisbert," where the performance group would perform two shows, and anybody could audition into a semesterly "Open Show." Tisbert was also featured on the WRCT Radio Station's "Carnival Broadcast," where they recorded some audio-only sketches to be played over the airwaves. Tisbert is sure to keep evolving over the next year, and we can't wait to see what they'll bring!



Message from the President

What an incredible year it has been for Scotch'n'Soda! Even amidst some admittedly trying times, we saw yet again amazing performances and engagement from our talented members: the huge glitz- and glamour-filled musical Catch Me If You Can, the first-ever college performance of The Summerland Project, and the exploration of new forms of comedy through The Bald Soprano. We also had another great iteration of NPP's ever-growing improv festival "Detour", a successful reorganization of Tisbert, and a virtual performance of an original play with New Works Coffeehouse. This has truly been a year of growth for S'n'S, and I am excited to see us continue this trajectory.

Of course, the year has not been without hardships. Due to COVID-19, Carnegie Mellon is currently running with all operations happening remotely, including student organizations. Even so, I am constantly amazed by our members' passion, resilience, and support for one another in the recent months. We have found new ways to do what we do, like our "S'n'Sings" performances and radio play. They have led to exciting collaborations with CMU's radio station WRTC – a collaboration that I hope we can continue even after returning to operations as normal. And social distancing hasn't stopped the incredible S'n'S community – members and alumni continue to interact through virtual black chairs ("black chairs" is what S'n'S members fondly call the spot in the Cohon University Center where you can frequently find members socializing).

In addition to virtual performances and hang-outs, we successfully elected a new Board of Directors! I am excited to see where they take the organization in the coming year. While the future is uncertain, we are continuing to find new ways for virtual performances and engagement. I am inspired every day by this organization and its members, and it has been an honor serving as President of Scotch'n'Soda.

I hope that you and your families are safe and well, and please know that you have the support of Scotch'n'Soda Theatre.

With gratitude and warm regards,
Joe Brauch

Welcoming the New Board!

Emily Schneider
President

Katia Peppas
Artistic Director

Madeline Easton
Vice President

Kanvi Shah
Managing Director

Remy Goldberg
Public Relations Coordinator

Gavin Grnja
Technical Coordinator

Cynthia Xu
Secretary

Gabi Augustin
General Membership Coordinator

Ayda Ozdoganlar
Executive Board Member